

The Boston Globe

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State reiterates its ACA assistance

Promise of action in continuing effort to pick up the slack

By Jason Laughlin
GLOBE STAFF

As Democrats spotlight affordability as a central campaign issue, Governor Maura Healey stood at a lectern Thursday to disclose the state's use of \$250 million from a trust fund to help Massachusetts residents confronting skyrocketing premiums for health insurance they get through the Affordable Care Act. "So here's what we're going to do," Healey said. "We're going to use this trust fund money to provide more financial support where the federal government has taken those

subsidies away," she said.

The promise of action, however, downplayed that the financial commitment was not new and had already been baked into January insurance bills.

Audrey Morse Gasteier, executive director of the Massachusetts Health Connector, said the financial bulkwork that benefited 270,000 residents is "part of the reason that we're hanging in there in terms of enrollment and keeping people covered."

But Thursday's announcement won't translate into any additional

help.

Healey's news conference coincided with the beginning of an election year in which three Republicans are vying for her job and voters are expected to be particularly focused on the state's high cost of living. One survey last year found Massachusetts had the second highest cost of living in the country. People who saw their insurance premiums increase this year said it was one pricey bill amid an onslaught of growing expenses.

"I can't believe how much it is when we go to the grocery store. Our

electricity has gone up," said Judith O'Gara, whose family was hit with a \$400 increase a month in insurance premiums for their ACA plan in January. "We were just bracing ourselves to try to stretch the paycheck further."

O'Gara, of Millis, is a part-time editor at community newspapers, and her husband is a self-employed computer animator and mural artist. She has added hours at work, she said, but it still wasn't enough to qualify for health coverage through her employer, leaving the couple to buy insurance through the connector.

SUBSIDIES, Page A7

Trump: Only my morality stops me

Says international law doesn't hold him back

By David E. Sanger, Tyler Pager, Katie Rogers, and Zolan Kanno-Youngs
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — President Trump declared Wednesday that his power as commander in chief is constrained only by his "own morality," brushing aside international law and other checks on his ability to use military might to strike, invade, or coerce nations around the world.

Asked in a wide-ranging interview with The New York Times if there are any limits on his global powers, Trump said: "Yeah, there is one thing. My own morality. My own mind. It's the only thing that can stop me."

"I don't need international law," he added. "I'm not looking to hurt people."

When pressed further about whether his administration needs to abide by international law, Trump said, "I do." But he made clear he would be the arbiter when such constraints applied to the United States.

"It depends what your definition of international law is," he said.

Trump's assessment of his own freedom to use any instrument of military, economic, or political power to cement US supremacy was the most blunt acknowledgment yet of his worldview. At its core is the concept that national strength, rather than laws, treaties, and conventions, should be the de-

TRUMP, Page A6

A FINE LINE



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Sunrise was an impressive sight on Thursday at Pleasure Bay in South Boston. The January thaw is likely to continue.

Disputes between Minnesota officials and the Trump administration intensified over who would investigate the killing of a woman by a federal agent. **A2.**

The driver of a BPS bus that struck and killed a kindergarten asserted his constitutional protection against self-incrimination in response to a civil suit. **B1.**

Nutritionists had mixed reactions to the new dietary guidelines unveiled by Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. **B1.**

Mass General Brigham plans to bring insurer Fallon Health into its plan. **B5.**

Alex Bregman or Bo Bichette? The pros and cons for the Red Sox. **C1.**



Spring fling

Friday: Mild but damp. High 45-50. Low 38-43.
Saturday: More of the same. High 44-49. Low 35-40.
Sunrise: 7:13 Sunset: 4:30
Weather and Comics, G6-7.

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A difficult decision on mass shooting site

Brown could keep it sealed, renovate, or raze entirely

By Alexa Gagosz, Shannon Larson, Travis Andersen, and Camilo Fonseca
GLOBE STAFF

PROVIDENCE — When students return to Brown University later this month, they will not be able to access multiple sections of the academic building that have been sealed off since a gunman opened fire on a study session in December, killing two students and injuring nine.

Schools that experience deadly mass shootings face a wrenching decision over what to do about the

scene of the violence, whether to preserve it as a memorial, renovate or alter it, or demolish it altogether and rebuild. It's a decision, experts said, that reflects the pressures schools face about trauma and the need to resume some sense of normal life.

At Brown, two lecture halls, eight adjacent classrooms, and neighboring restrooms and hallways on the first floor, where the shooting took place, will remain closed for the time being, Brown's president, Christina H. Paxson, wrote in a message to the campus this week.

"It's the right thing to seal those [rooms] off," said Kevin LoGiudice, a Brown graduate student who worked in the building. "But it's going to also be strange having a constant reminder of what happened be-

hind those walls."

Returning to the busy physics and engineering building, even with part of it closed, will be difficult for many students and staff, mental health specialists said.

"Some people are able to return to a location and resume their daily lives," said Jillian Amodio, a licensed mental health professional in Maryland who has treated many people after shootings. "However, many people find that reentering the site of a traumatic event is not good for their mental health, and cutting off contact with that space is the best option for them."

In some cases, communities have chosen to raze and rebuild buildings where shootings took place.

BROWN, Page A10

For relatives of overdose victims, some much-needed help

Fund will assist with funeral expenses, other costs

By Chris Serres
GLOBE STAFF

At times, Sandra Spadafora feels trapped in the memory of the September afternoon in 2019, when she learned her 33-year-old son, Andrew Brown, had gone missing.

There were frantic calls to Boston area hospitals and drug detoxification centers before a Suffolk County medical examiner confirmed her worst fears: A bruised body that matched Brown's description — with a distinctive tattoo saying "Lost Soul" — had been found in a Boston MBTA station. His official cause of death was a fentanyl overdose.

Yet, before Spadafora could process her grief, another painful realization set in. After spending thousands of dollars on treatment and essentials for her adult son, who had struggled with substance abuse since he was a teenager,

Spadafora had no money left to pay for a casket or a traditional burial. Instead, Brown would have to be cremated.

"Going through his death was devastating enough, but now you've got to worry about how to pay for everything," said Spadafora, who lives in Saugus. "It added to the stress and the grief."

Now, almost three decades into an opioid crisis that has claimed more than 1 million lives, Massachusetts is poised to become one of the first states to create a fund offering direct financial relief to families who have lost relatives to overdoses.

In interviews, parents across Massachusetts described going to extraordinary lengths to rescue their adult children from opioid addiction, sometimes draining their retirement accounts or borrowing on credit cards to pay for

OVERDOSES, Page A10



BARRY CHIN/GLOBE STAFF

Sandra Spadafora held a photo of her son, Andrew Brown, who died of a fentanyl overdose in 2019. She did not have enough money left for a burial.